

Charts in PowerPoint allow you to explain complex figures in an illustrative format, and so make comprehension of data easier. Let's say that in your presentation you want to tell the audience about the amount of rainfall *and* the percentage of rainfall with respect to land cover in some states. Words and numbers are not likely to drive the information across. A chart will not only convey the information better, it will also make the presentation more interesting.

"Charts," in the context of PowerPoint, refers to graphs; they are not about the steps in a process or about events in a sequence. Now, charts in MS Word, PowerPoint, or Publisher cannot do without Excel. MS Excel needs to be installed for you to be able to generate graphs in PowerPoint. Also, while installing Excel, make sure you also install Office Shared Features and Office Tools; otherwise, again, you can't use charts in PowerPoint.

A way out—if you really don't want to install Excel, for whatever reason—is to insert a graph by copying and pasting from an external source (such as a JPEG image).

13.1 Exploring the Terms

Assuming you're not familiar with charts, be aware that you do need to go through this section before moving further into this chapter. Much of what follows assumes you've read through this section.

Here are the terms you'll come across when working with charts, as illustrated in the screenshot alongside.

- **Plot Area:** The area of the chart itself, where the data is represented, apart from legends and data labels
- **Worksheet:** This is similar to a table where data is entered to create the chart. When the worksheet is displayed on the slide along with a chart, it is called a data table.
- **Values:** The numbers with which a chart is outlined represent the values. The size of the columns, bars, pie slices, and the like depends on these values.